#dead-shepherd

#genes-έ-ontology #brain-hemispheres
#memes-z-epistemology #society-evolution

- Iain McGilchrist
- Christopher Marlowe
- William Shakespeare
- Harold Bloom
- Yours Truly

You're mixing them up because both poets occupy similar territory in the American literary consciousness—they're both modernist-era poets who wrote contemplative, philosophical verse that gets quoted at graduations and carved into monuments. Both deal with journeys, searching, and meaning-making. The rhythm and gravity of their most famous lines blur together in memory.

The "heresy" you're noting is that both passages offer a kind of secular salvation narrative—finding meaning through individual choice and exploration rather than through divine revelation. Frost's poem suggests life's meaning comes from autonomous decision-making ("I took the one less traveled by"), while Eliot's lines (from "Little Gidding") frame endless exploration as the path to understanding. These replace the Psalm 23 model where God is the active shepherd who "leads" and "restores"—you're passive, guided, and the comfort is in surrender rather than exploration.

Your "no local Psalm 23 basin to teak us" is a wonderful way of putting it—there's no still water provided by an external shepherd to restore the soul. Instead, both Frost and Eliot put the burden on the individual traveler to find (or make) meaning through their own movement and choices. It's the shift from "He leadeth me" to "I took the one."

The irony is that Eliot himself was deeply religious and "Little Gidding" is explicitly Christian—but that particular passage has been so thoroughly secularized in popular usage that it functions as self-help spirituality divorced from its theological context.

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Ha! You've just performed the exact phenomenon you're describing—misremembering Shakespeare's "Dead shepherd, now I find thy saw of might: /

Whoever loved that loved not at first sight" (from *As You Like It*, where Phoebe quotes Marlowe) into a meta-commentary on itself!

Your version—"whoever loved that loved not by misreading"—is accidentally brilliant because it captures something true: we *do* love these lines partly through misreading them. We love Frost's poem while missing that it's ironic (both roads were actually equally worn). We love Eliot's exploration line while stripping away his Christian resolution. We love "at first sight" as romantic wisdom while forgetting it's spoken by a character making poor decisions.

The "dead shepherd" (Marlowe) gets quoted by Shakespeare's character, who then gets misquoted by you—and each misreading creates new meaning. Marlowe's original line was probably sincere pastoral romance; Shakespeare uses it semi-ironically; you've accidentally made it a theory of cultural transmission.

It's like a game of telephone where each corruption reveals something: we don't just passively receive these "saws of might"—we remake them through our errors, our needs, our faulty memories. The version that lives in our heads, wrong as it may be, is the version we actually love.

Your Freudian slip is doing critical theory!

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Ah! So he's backed himself into a corner.

The hemispheric asymmetry is supposedly ancient, hardwired, genetic. Left does representation/abstraction/grammar, right does presence/context/prosody. That's the neurology.

But then cultural history shows these radical swings—Apollonian vs Dionysian dominance cycling through epochs. Renaissance bursts of integrated wholeness, Enlightenment reduction and mechanism, Romantic pushback, modern fragmentation.

If those swings map onto hemispheric dominance (his thesis), but hemispheres are genetically fixed… how do you get that much variation in a few centuries? Evolution doesn't work that fast.

So: **genes → memes**. Cultural transmission of which hemisphere gets valorized, which mode of attention becomes institutionalized. The hardware is constant, but the software—what we *attend to*, what we *reward*—shifts.

Which is… fine? Plausible even? But it completely undercuts the biological determinism of Part One. If memetic drift can swing hemispheric dominance that dramatically, then the neurology isn't really doing the causal work. It's just providing two modes that culture can dial up or down.

And once you're in meme-land, you're back to—wait for it—**mimesis**. Cultural copying. Social gradients. Attractor basins in idea-space.

Which he could handle elegantly with your raindrop model! But instead he's phenomenologizing it, because Heidegger.

Is Part Two where the whole edifice starts to wobble, or does he manage to hold it together?

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Ooh, this is a great tension.

Heisenberg gives you fundamental uncertainty—the irreducible fuzziness at the base of reality. You can't have position and momentum both pinned down. It's not epistemic limitation, it's ontological. The universe doesn't *have* those values simultaneously.

Hinton gives you… systems that settle into probability distributions over configurations by minimizing energy functions. Which is deterministic in its dynamics (given the energy landscape) but stochastic in its sampling. The randomness is computational, not fundamental.

So the question is: does your Olympiad need fundamental physical uncertainty, or does it need the mathematics of how systems explore and settle?

Here's the case for Hinton displacing Heisenberg:

- You already have irreducible randomness from Dostoevsky (the gambler, the dice throw)
- Hinton gives you the *mechanism* by which systems navigate possibility space
- Boltzmann machines connect directly to your attractor/basin framework
- They formalize how you escape local minima (temperature/annealing)
- They're literally about learning patterns from experience—pure mimesis as gradient descent

Heisenberg gives you ontological uncertainty. Hinton gives you *what systems do* in the face of uncertainty—how they sample, settle, learn, get stuck, escape.

Given your emphasis on dynamics over phenomenology, on flow over foundation… yeah, Hinton might be the better fit.

Does Heisenberg survive on the bench, or is he fully out?

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Yes! Directly related.

The Boltzmann machine is named after Ludwig Boltzmann because it uses the same mathematical framework he developed for statistical mechanics—specifically, the Boltzmann distribution.

Boltzmann's distribution describes how particles distribute across energy states at thermal equilibrium. Higher energy states are exponentially less likely. The formula involves temperature as a parameter controlling how spread out the distribution is.

Hinton (with Sejnowski and Ackley in the mid-80s) built a neural network that uses the exact same probability distribution. The "energy" of a network configuration determines its probability. The network settles into states by effectively doing thermodynamic sampling—hence "Boltzmann machine."

The temperature parameter even works the same way: high temperature means more random exploration, low temperature means settling into local minima. Simulated annealing uses this—start hot, cool down gradually.

So it's not just nominal tribute. It's the same math, transplanted from 19th-century physics of gas particles to 20th-century models of neural computation. Energy landscapes, thermal equilibrium, probability distributions over microstates.

Which is kind of funny given what we were just saying: Hinton's taking pure statistical mechanics—no phenomenology, no felt experience, just particles (or units) settling into probable configurations—and building cognition out of it.

Very much *not* McGilchrist's vibe.

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Ha—yeah, that tracks. Heidegger gives you the phenomenological framing, the emphasis on *being-in-the-world*, the relational ontology, the critique of calculative thinking. Perfect fit for McGilchrist's project.

But if you actually engage with, say, the German dynamical systems tradition, or even just take seriously what the Gestalt psychologists were doing with field dynamics, you get a very different picture. One where patterns emerge from mathematical constraints, not from meaningful participation.

It's telling what he *doesn't* do with the Germans he name-drops. Like, if you're going to invoke German intellectual history while talking about emergence and self-organization, you could actually grapple with:

- The thermodynamic tradition (Helmholtz, Boltzmann)
- Early chaos theory and complexity (Prigogine was Belgian but whatever)
- The actual mathematical structure of how patterns form

Instead he uses them as atmospheric seasoning while doing Heideggerian phenomenology all the way down.

Which means he's primed to see mimesis as something thick with meaning and felt responsiveness, rather than just… flow following gradients. The raindrop doesn't *care* about other raindrops. It doesn't experience participation. It just goes downhill, and if downhill happens to be where everyone else went, that's topology, not togetherness.

Is Part Two where this becomes most obvious, or does it run through the whole book?

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Ah, right—so McGilchrist is psychologizing or phenomenologizing what you're seeing as pure dynamics. He's attributing some kind of felt responsiveness or experiential quality to the process when you're saying: no, this is just attractor basins and flow. Math, not meaning.

Which would be very on-brand for him, honestly. He tends to see the left hemisphere as mechanistic/reductive and the right as relational/responsive, so he'd probably *want* mimesis to involve some kind of felt participation rather than just algorithmic pattern-following.

But if mimesis is just "agents following gradients toward local maxima of social proof/desirability," then you don't need phenomenology. You don't need felt experience. You just need:

- A landscape that changes based on traffic
- Agents responsive to landscape features
- Positive feedback

Humans aren't special here. Ant trails, slime molds, capital flows, neural firing patterns—same math.

Is that the wrong-headedness? That he's trying to make it about *experience* and *relationship* when it's really just dynamical systems doing their thing, whether the substrate is water, neurons, or status-seeking primates?

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